7

BEING MRS ROCHESTER

Empathy in Live Action Role-Playing

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The beginning. In the ballroom.

The moment the larp begins. We have done one dance "off" but in our ball clothes to see that we all fit in the ballroom and that dancing so many at once works. I am standing across from a captain with whom I had been dancing the practice dance. Game masters [GM] explain what will happen next: A couple of opening lines about what will constitute the first act of the larp: Spring. Then opening music. When the music ends, the larp commences and it commences with a dance–with the partner standing in front of us. A GM steps forward and reads the lines. I stand very quiet, listening. Then the music begins. A very tense moment. I am looking down at the floor intensely concentrating, but without thinking. The moment the music ends, a rush of adrenaline. I am concentrated not only in my mind, but in my body, every joint prepared for this moment. I look up, smile at the captain. I'm acutely aware that I'm now Mrs Rochester. A bit of a bustle about joining our quadruples. The practices and practicalities of dancing help my body to relax into character. The music begins–and so do I. Such a blessing that the larp begins with a dance. To move my body with the dancing. Interacting in silence with other players helps me ease into character. I'm still quite incredulous about the whole thing. At the end of the dance, when the captain escorts me back to the side, I'm feeling confident and at ease. My body has become Mrs Rochester.

This is how one of this chapter's authors, Petra, experienced the opening of the live action role-playing game (larp) *Fortune & Felicity*. These are field notes

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that take us to the moment Petra, the player, takes on the role of Mrs Rochester, embarking on a journey through polite society of Regency England. In the scene, music and dancing are transitional devices, marking the liminal space between the real world and the storyworld. In the real world, there has been a practice dance already, "off" being the term used in larp to signal events and actions taking place outside the storyworld. As the second dance begins, Petra assumes the character of Mrs Rochester ('the larp commences and it commences with a dance'), and, for a moment, there is a poignant, embodied experience of being both.

Fortune & Felicity was a so-called Nordic larp, which lasted for five days in Sweden in May 2017.[1] One hundred and fifty people from Sweden and abroad, of different ages and backgrounds, gathered in the historical Swedish spa resort Medevi Brunn, to immerse in the storyworld of Jane Austen's novels and to take part in a unique larp experience. In full regency costume, the players co-created a storyworld inspired by Austen's novels, developing plots, relations and characters to form a weblike multitude of stories and experiences. Both of us participated fully: Petra playing Mrs Rochester and Sara, Mr Rosewood.

In this chapter, we will make extensive use of Petra's fieldnotes, letting them guide our argument about how the capacity for empathy enables play and opens up a potential for individual and social transformation in larp. The chapter is structured according to the unfolding of the larp, more specifically Petra's experiences as Mrs Rochester and as a player, using three scenes as points of departure for our analysis of empathy in larp. Each scene is followed by a discussion of a specific aspect of empathy. The scenes (in the following referred to as "the battledore scene", "the compromise scene" and "the breakfast scene") are presented in chronological order. They should not, however, be regarded as particularly significant plot elements in the larp as a whole. Rather, they should be seen as thick descriptions of impactful moments in Mrs Rochester's journey and in Petra's own experience of the larp (Figure 7.1).

The opening of the larp in the ballroom (account above) marks the beginning of *Fortune & Felicity* and the entry into its storyworld, facilitated both by design elements (the ballroom and dance practice) and by individual player action. In the battledore scene, the larp is well underway: Everyone is having a picnic, socialising and enjoying the outdoors. Mrs Rochester is happily engaging in a battledore game – an early form of badminton – with her beloved brother. The field notes of this scene recount not only the happy interaction between Mrs Rochester and Phineas, but also Petra's positive experiences as a player in that moment. In the compromise scene, Mrs Rochester finds herself in a precarious situation, taking a stroll alone with a man who has not been introduced to her family, something considered highly improper in Regency England. The field notes deal with how the feelings and actions of player and character permeate each other, making the experience highly complex. The scene agitates Mrs Rochester and leaves Petra feeling disturbed. The breakfast scene marks the end of the larp and describes the troublesome transition from the fictional storyworld back to the real world.



FIGURE 7.1 Mrs Rochester.

Credit: Frida Edgar-Selvén and Kalle Lantz

Empathy, as we will show, is closely connected to the immersive and participatory nature of larp. The battledore scene helps us explore intersubjective empathy, that is empathy for another person, and demonstrates how empathy is both emotional and embodied. The compromise scene guides us into an exploration of intrasubjective empathy, that is the emotional and embodied empathy the player has for the character and vice versa. The breakfast scene highlights how empathy and immersion work together to create an experience that is potentially transformative for the player in the real world.

A collaborative and embodied story

A highly ambitious larp, *Fortune & Felicity* demonstrated some key characteristics of the form. Put succinctly, larp can be understood as a 'collaborative and embodied story' (Lundell, 2014, p. 50). The most salient aspects are well captured by the editors of the seminal larp anthology *The Foundation Stone of Nordic Larp*:

> In larp, you usually portray a character in the same way you might in a stage play, physically acting out whatever you wish to do. Unlike a stage play, there is no script and no audience, just the setting, props, and a few details everyone has agreed on–names, relationships, and the like. Together, you and the other players explore the story you choose to tell together.
>
> *(Saitta et al., 2014, p. 11).*

The "live" in live action role-playing is central. Everything that happens is acted out physically in interaction between players in the game, which means that larp also needs to take place in a physical space, requiring props and physical objects to generate and facilitate action. Furthermore, "live" also means that larping happens in real time. Although there are some designed plot structures in place (such as characters, central themes and some plot directions), much of the action and interaction is improvised. Such improvisation generates a network of multiple plotlines developed by players, making larp a fluid, unpredictable and to a certain extent uncontrollable form of storytelling, where events happen without necessarily being known by anyone besides the players directly involved. All participants in a larp must take an active part in play, meaning that there is no room for either an audience or passive observers. Players are not professional actors (although they of course can be), but rather collaborators, telling a story together. Generally, this makes larp a very non-hierarchical cultural form of expression, where everyone participates on equal terms. What holds the players and the actions together is a storyworld, a shared sense of the 'fictional reality' (Harviainen et al., 2018), which both sets the scope for possible actions and includes the material reality of location, objects and bodies. Players relate to that fictional reality from a first-person perspective, a relation that can be described as that of a 'first-person audience'

(Stenros & Montola, 2010b; Montola & Holopainen, 2012). The conflation of the lived experience of the player with that of the character has been described as a kind of 'player-character perceptual unity' through which 'at least part of the player's sensorial input is supposed to be identical with the character's' (Mochocki, 2018, p. 97). This is what makes immersion possible.

Nordic larp can be described as a specific tradition, or genre, within larp. *Fortune & Felicity* came out of this tradition. It is decidedly avant-garde, pushing against the boundaries of what larp can be and do, with designers and players working together to develop and explore the intricacies of its form. Immersion is key. Nordic larp 'spends more time telling stories that emphasize naturalistic emotion, it emphasizes collective, rather than competitive storytelling, and it takes its stories fairly seriously much of the time' (Saitta et al., 2014, p. 11). This means that designers and participants alike are focusing on strong, even difficult, emotional play, experimenting with ways of furthering powerful experiences. This ambition is reflected in design choices, meta-techniques and action. On the design level, this happens most clearly in the choice of theme. Examples from Nordic larps include domestic violence, incest, addiction, bullying and catastrophe (Stenros & Montola, 2010a).[2] To enhance the intensity of the experience, Nordic larp designers make active use of physical space. This can mean, for example, not only choosing a location that is suggestive of the theme of the larp, but also designing the space in a way that enhances players' room and limits to act. It means including design elements that make larping on difficult themes both possible and safe, for example, the use of so-called "meta-techniques" that allow players to engage in actions like having sex and exerting physical violence without actually doing it. In terms of player action, Nordic larp privileges a certain type of play, and there is a strong agreement in the Nordic larp community on the expectations of players to engage and, importantly, collaborate to create strong, immersive situations and emotional play.

As has been argued, immersion is potentially transformative (Bowman, 2018; Bowman et al., 2025; Hugaas & Bowman, 2019). Placing oneself in unusual or even strange situations, physically, emotionally and intellectually, and taking action in those situations, can create a sense of understanding and empathy which in turn can allow for a deeper awareness of the situations and precariousness of others. The strong collaborative and egalitarian ethos of the school of Nordic larp, alongside the often-pronounced ambition to engage with political themes, power relations and social norms, means that social transformation is often at the heart of larps in this tradition. This was true also of *Fortune & Felicity.* While it superficially resembled a kind of re-enactment event in the style of the Jane Austen Festival in Bath (janeausten.co.uk), *Fortune & Felicity* emphasised gender oppression and economic inequalities and encouraged players to explore these themes. Furthermore, in alignment with the Nordic larp tradition, *Fortune & Felicity* was both designed and acted in a way that furthered practices of empathy and care. Rather than emphasising the historicity of this larp, we see empathy and practices of care as central to social transformation in the present and in the future.

Fortune & Felicity – *A Jane Austen LARP*

Fortune & Felicity was a creative re-imagining of Austen's world and, although neither Elizabeth Bennet nor Emma Knightley actually appeared in the larp, characters, events and plotlines were often clearly recognisable from the novels (e.g. the ball, Figure 7.2). For the larp to work, structures needed to be in place. Before the larp, players were assigned characters and organised into groups. This provided a framework within which both actions and relations could be developed as the larp proceeded. Family relations, social status and income were made explicit, determining the scope of action, as well as how to behave and dress. All of these features worked together in a creative, partly uncontrolled, whole. Thus, for five days, without a script, but aided by the structural features of the game and a number of off-game workshops and other exercises, we improvised and interacted, made conversation, fell in love, were betrayed, plotted to create and destroy romantic attachments and revisited sinful pasts. In the words of the designers, *Fortune & Felicity,* this gave participants the chance to 'form [their] own personal Austen novel' (Westerling & Hultman, 2017).

Fortune & Felicity was designed and organised by Anna Westerling and Anders Hultman, both experienced larp designers and central figures in the Nordic larp community. Nordic larp traditions in larp design were clearly evidenced in the elaborate structure of *Fortune & Felicity*. In the larp, the real place Medevi Brunn



FIGURE 7.2 Outside the ballroom.

Credit: Frida Edgar-Selvén and Kalle Lantz

(a small spa town with a central street, a church, a number of houses, including living quarters, a ballroom and a tearoom, as well as a spa pavilion for taking the waters) is transformed into Primrose Park. Importantly, the space was designed to emphasise economic inequalities and gender oppression. Poorer families had their living quarters at one end of the village street, rich families on the other. Certain spaces were designated as off-limits to any respectable woman, and the high street was used as a space to "parade" women and to display them and their attributes. To further emphasise economic inequalities, which in fact dictated player interaction, players wore tags stating family name and yearly income.

Player immersion was not only supported by physical space, but also time. The fact that the larp took place over several days and nights (even sleeping was in-game) heightened the sense of being absorbed in its storyworld. Meta-techniques were extensively used to enable players to immerse themselves in their characters in powerful ways. For example, there were workshops on physical comportment, where women learned to curtsey, limit their stride and lower their eyes in public, whereas men practiced nodding politely and how to take manly walks, adapting players' bodies to Regency polite society and adding to the pervasive experience of being part of that society. This experience was the result of both intentional design and player action.

In our discussion, we will follow the fortunes and misfortunes of Mrs Rochester. In the pre-larp design material, sent out to players beforehand, Mrs Rochester is described as a wealthy woman, married to an admiral who got rich during the war. She lives at Darkwood Manor, waiting for the return of her husband, who is out at sea. She has recently been reunited with her beloved older brother Phineas and is socialising with her extended family, the Creamhills, who are at the pinnacle of polite society.

As discussed earlier, larp does not allow for non-participating observers, something which directly impacted how we as researchers could access the larp. We had to participate fully, immerse ourselves in our characters and in the storyworld, rather than adopting a distant, observational stance. Throughout the larp, it became increasingly clear how hard it was to find moments to step out of the larp experience, something which can be seen in the fieldnotes quoted in this chapter. We had to make a decision to fully engage with the actions and interactions of the larp, trusting that the strong experiences would be stored in our memory and be possible to access even without the possibility for moment-by-moment notetaking. This inevitably affected our analysis, but, in the end, enriched our understanding of all aspects of larping in ways which would not have been possible without full participation. The fieldnotes reflect both this realisation and the process of simultaneously participating in the larp and attempting to understand it from an analytical perspective.

Empathy

In our discussion, we will be in conversation with philosophy professor Heidi Maibom and her emphasis on empathy as a *practice* in her book *The Space Between*, which we find helpful in exploring the complexities of our larp

experience. The most general, and perhaps commonsense, understanding of empathy is that it involves feeling *with* somebody else, to emotionally know what another person is experiencing. From a psychological and philosophical perspective, there is general agreement that empathy indeed happens and works, but grasping what it involves as a practice is more difficult to theorise. This is what Maibom explores in detail, making her argument very useful in analysing how larps like *Fortune & Felicity,* in both design and player action, integrate empathy as a tool to explore oneself and others and the power dynamics between them.

Maibom's starting point is empathy's capacity to 'open our eyes to a greater reality' (p. 6). She argues that we always come to the world immersed, that is, embodied with a perspective. To adopt another's perspective, then, presents a way for us to 'overcome our own limited view of the world, other people, and ourselves' (p. 6). Thus, she argues, we 'often use empathy to give us a fuller, more complete picture of reality' (p. 8). Empathy is a genuine interest in others, which also requires us to take the time and devote our attention to others rather than ourselves. Empathy, then, is a skill that we can rehearse and train, even though it is hard work. We argue that *Fortune & Felicity* produced a space where such skills were both designed and practiced.

Intersubjective empathy

Fundamentally, empathy implies seeing the world with another person's eyes, to embody, if even for just a moment, attitudes and thoughts that are 'closer to hers than to our own' (Maibom, 2022, p. 14). This is to take an agent perspective, where the 'immediate, unreflected way of thinking about ourselves and our actions from "inside our agency"' (p. 81) is adopted in the way we relate to the other person. In Maibom's terms, this presents the possibility of bridging the epistemic and emotional gaps between me-and-you. While our experiences are intricately shaped by historical, social and culturally specific situations that cannot be fully known by another, this does not, in Maibom's terms, impede empathy:

> A good part of what constitutes our experiences are features that most human beings share: our physical structure, the capabilities of our bodies, species- and culture-relative interests, and so on. These are exactly the kinds of things that we can adopt in taking another's point of view.
>
> *(p. 58)*

Yet, empathy is not about full identification with another person, but rather about understanding, which Maibom calls a 'contextual act' (p. 23). This means focusing on the situation the other person is in and understanding their motivations and reactions.

Maibom even claims that, in doing this, exactness or detail is not the main issue. Importantly, we do not need to understand exactly or even in any detail,

what a person is thinking or experiencing. Instead, the point is 'the significance of what is happening to them, why it matters to them and their attitude towards people and the world. It is about the other person's general attitude and valuations' (p. 157). To accurately gauge a person's feelings is less important than devoting effort and care to take that person's perspective. In fact, diffuse mental states are enough for empathy:

> What is most important is another person's warmth. That is, we are greatly concerned with perceived intent, friendliness, helpfulness, sincerity, trustworthiness, morality, fairness, generosity, honesty, and tolerance. These are all characteristics of a person or their actions that are highly diagnostic of what we can hope for from any relationship, cooperation, or other joint venture with them.
>
> *(p. 173)*

Intrasubjective empathy

So far, we have discussed empathy in terms of taking an agent's perspective on another person. But empathy means not only understanding others, but also oneself. Empathy is also intrasubjective. In larp, in which immersion is central, this aspect of empathy is particularly salient, as it sheds light on the complex interrelation between player and character. Taking the perspective of another, in larp, is not only about other players and characters but also, and perhaps most powerfully, about taking your own character's perspective. This complex, ongoing perspective-taking troubles the border between the subjectivity of the player and that of the character. Intrasubjective empathy is thus linked both to Maibom's notion of emotional contagion and to the larp concept of "bleed", that is the permeability between player and character in larp (Hugaas, 2024; there are also numerous articles on nordiclarp.org that shed light on this interesting phenomenon).

An important aspect of empathy, according to Maibom, concerns imagination. This, we argue, is important for empathy in larp. When focusing on the situation and the actors involved in that situation, you need to imagine what the situation implies for the other person or your own character. Rather than only relying on one's own experiences, one needs to replay in one's mind *'what I imagine goes on in yours'* (p. 29). Key concepts in empathy for Maibom, then, are understanding and imagination. This approach to empathy and its aspects helps us understand our experience of *Fortune & Felicity*, in which historical accuracy (or fidelity to Austen's novels) had much less significance than the imaginative capacity to engage with empathic interaction and emotional play.

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Playing Battledore

Playing Battledore with Phineas after the picnic. The two of us trying to reach 10–not a competitive game but co-work. It gave me a flashback to *A Room with a View*, when the main character Lucy and her brother are playing badminton. There is an instant flash-back to that scene and the physical interaction between the sister and brother which also says something about their psychological and social interaction. Joking, happy, free, open and absolutely loving–but still within the realms of the socially acceptable. Phineas diving after a ball grassing his pants. Me moving around freely in my clothes, careless. Feeling my badminton muscles remembering their movement. Not so concerned about how I am perceived. It felt good to move my body, even in that dress. This despite the fact that the Captain was playing with his love interest before us, me fully knowing his presence around the space. I did not even look for him, concentrating at the game. Also, aware about Mr Rosewood playing with his son next to us. A strange sensation, not knowing her character, but knowing Sara. But their game had a very different character–they were competing. This put Phineas' and my game in such a different perspective. Playing with Phineas gave a sense of deeply knowing each other without having to display it in any fashion. This scene made my character develop into more of a free-thinker. I could refer to my brother and my close relation with him (and being able to move my body freely with him) to explain why I thought and acted the way I did. And why I felt that I could develop my thinking in a more unconventional manner.

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As we have shown, larp design plays a crucial role in creating the possibility and potential for empathy. In the pre-larp design material, the relation between Mrs Rochester and her brother is described as "very close" (Figure 7.3). She has had a number of near-fatal miscarriages, a vulnerability which her brother is aware of and worries about. In the background material, it is stated that Mrs Rochester wants to meet her brother at Primrose Park and 'have a good time with him', providing an emotional precondition for their relationship and how players might develop their interactions. In off-game workshops, throughout the larp, the relationship between sister and brother developed both between the two players and with the involvement of the wider family group and game masters. Meta-techniques also helped to develop and explore the relation. One example is when the two players and their family try out a scene, like a play in the play, in which they find out that Mrs Rochester's absent husband has turned pirate. This scene subsequently became true in the storyworld (he did in fact become a pirate). This also became

an internal joke, which strengthened the bond between sister and brother, opening up the space for empathy based not on fully identifying with the other, but instead, having a sense of, as Maibom has it, 'the other person's general attitude and valuations' of a situation (in this case the absurd social problem of losing one's husband to piracy). Another crucial design element is, as we have discussed, the planning and use of physical space, creating the grounds for battledore and offering the possibility for players to use the sport as part of their interactions. Hence, the sensations of trust, carefreeness and joy that inform the battledore scene are afforded by a number of design elements. However, for empathic interaction to happen, players cannot only rely on game design or the guidance of game masters. Substantial emotional and embodied labour is also needed in player action and interaction.

Empathy is most obviously about understanding, sharing and feeling emotions; as Maibom argues, it gives perspectives on the world and is a form of emotional perspective taking. Despite the unbridgeable gap between 'me-and-you', we have access to expressive phenomena such as blushing, laughing and crying and we apply emotional labour to read, understand and relate to them. Importantly, moreover, expressed emotions are felt emotions. When we mirror each other's emotional expressions, we come to feel the same emotion as the person we mirror. We feel sad with the person who is crying. Thus, we do not only observe and understand expressions, we also catch emotions. This emotional contagion, in Maibom's terms, means that '[w]hen I say, "I feel your pain", it may well seem to me that I am' (p. 128). This is, of course, also true of positive emotional states, as is expressed in the battledore scene where joy and ease develop between sister and brother, as well as between player and player.

The emotional contagion between brother and sister had lasting effects throughout the game. The pre-larp character description included a prompt for the positive bond between brother and sister, but the feelings of closeness and mutual joy that informed the relationship were mainly the result of the emotional, empathic labour of the players. This mood provided a space of relief which helped the development of character and play, as expressed in this fieldnote: 'There are so many loving scenes with my brother, that really made me laugh. A true match, and Phineas' and my interaction really changed how my character developed'. Mrs Rochester, thus, changed from a troubled, anxious woman to a confident, freethinking person. The ability to experience effortless and deep understanding for another player in positive terms, interestingly, also informed other, more challenging situations. As we shall see, playing disturbing and even threatening situations similarly required intensive labour involving both emotional and embodied empathy.

Empathy not only works through emotion but also through embodiment. Maibom discusses this in terms of entrainment, where 'we commonly change our behaviours so as to fit those of people around us, whether we are aware of it or not', creating synergy between their embodied behaviours, which in turn 'facilitates learning and liking, causes attraction and greases the wheel of social interaction' (p. 116). In the battledore scene, the non-competitive character of the



FIGURE 7.3 Mrs Rochester's brother Phineas Creamhill.
Credit: Frida Edgar-Selvén and Kalle Lantz

game emphasises the loving relationship between the siblings. In the larp design, battledore was framed as a leisure activity without strict rules, affording spontaneity and playfulness – it took place on a lawn which also served as a picnic area, in everyday dress and with no clear results or wins. The reciprocity of hitting the shuttlecock to each other supported interaction and created a space for collaborative development of the characters and the relationship between them. Game design and individual action work together. Grassing one's pants, carelessly and freely moving around in a dress designed to regulate the way women behave and show their bodies, are expressions of the synergy that develops as the siblings reflect and prompt each other's behaviour. As Maibom has it, our responses to the environment 'enable synergistic relationships by our learning to modify our behaviour in rhythm with it. This is not a reflective activity. It is immediate and thoughtless and yet extremely sophisticated and complex' (p. 118).

The battledore scene shows how the players' previous experiences make themselves present in the fictional world. Entrainment, in other words, involves not only the immediate behaviour or interaction but also previous embodied experiences. The evocation of the player's teenage experiences as an avid badminton player meant that her muscle memory momentarily took precedence over the bodily constraints of the character, allowing her to move in a way not considered appropriate in the fictional world of early nineteenth-century *Fortune & Felicity*. Additionally, the player's flashback to a scene from a 1985 film, based on a novel from 1908, *A Room with a View,* similarly affected how the embodied interaction worked in the scene. Though not verbally expressed, remembering the scene from the film allowed her to align her bodily movements to those of her brother, despite differences in gendered behavioural norms. This seemingly simple and direct sporting activity, in other words, is in fact a complex web of bodily movement, interaction and actualised memories and past experiences.

When bodies align themselves in this way, in the battledore scene as well as in the larp as a whole, a form of synergy is created where, following Chemero and Maibom, 'something arises from our interaction that goes beyond the sum of our respective contributions' (p. 117). In the larp, players' engagement in telling a story together, within the frames and prompts provided by design elements, created a system of interaction in which individual actions constantly contributed to the whole.

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Mrs Rochester risks being compromised

Taking one step out on the veranda, I see Jeremy Steele coming towards us. I rush back, telling the captain that I can't leave, while hiding quickly behind the hallway door. My head is racing, my heart is pounding, I'm feeling weak.

> The Captain steps out to meet Jeremy Steele. A hard knot in my stomach, feeling nauseous. Why? Thinking that I am now ruined. That there would be a scene. I'm feeling betrayed. Why? Thinking that the two men "off" had conspired to produce this scene to create drama–drama I do not want and have not asked for. Fear that I would have to play shame throughout the remainder of the larp. Playing exorcised woman. I hear that the captain is trying to stall him. Even asking him if this is his quarter–which it is–and what room he is in. I surmise that he has done this to me so that I can sneak into the house and hide somewhere in the other direction of where Mr Steele lives. In my distress, I immediately forget the number. I also have the time to think that it is too risky to move since Mr Steele is facing my direction, and decide to stay where I was. Maybe my body was freezing like a little mouse, not daring to move? Facing the wall, as in shame, my head down, trying to make myself completely unnoticeable, shrinking into the wall. I stay extremely quiet hearing that the captain can no longer stall the man and has to let him through. My heart is beating like mad. As I see Mr Steele in the corner of my eye passing through the corridor, I see my only chance and with a couple of light small steps I'm out of the door, expecting to hear Steele call out any moment. But, to my surprise, he doesn't. A feeling of incredulity flash across my mind–what was the meaning of this? Why contrive this scene only to let me go? The captain and I continue as if nothing has happened, and he seems very calm and happy. I had survived! After this we were meant to meet Phineas to do some archery. And in my new vein of free-thinking I had planned to do some archery. Coming there, I soon realised that my hands were shaking so much that there was no way in the world that I could do any archery and had to do a lot of explaining as to why I would not even try–especially since a lot of ladies tried–including Lady Creamhill.

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In stark contrast to the battledore scene, the scene above reeks of fear and a feeling of being trapped. Mrs Rochester has unwittingly put herself in a situation where she risks being compromised by the impropriety of taking a walk alone with a man, in this case the Captain (Figure 7.4).

The scene demonstrates the emotional and intellectual struggles to deal with this situation. Interestingly, fear is felt by character and player alike: the pounding heart and trembling hands of the player embody the fear of the character Mrs Rochester. If Mrs Rochester is afraid, the player's body expresses her fear, even though the player is not in a dangerous situation herself. This is what immersion, a desired state in Nordic larp, is all about. Drawing on the work of Hatfield, Cacioppo and Rapson, Maibom points out that 'bodily adjustments affect how we feel. When we mimic the types of expressions that are typically associated with certain emotions, we come to feel these emotions as a result. This helps us

figure out how it feels to experience them' (p. 113). The knot in the stomach, the nausea, are physical responses of the player to the emotion of fear conditioned by the gender oppression of Mrs Rochester's world. Instead of the liberation felt playing battledore, in this scene, another sport – archery – affords no relief, escape or independence, as she – both player and character – is unable to make use of this opportunity, since her hands – both player's and character's – are shaking so much. In other words, the "affordance" created by the larp design – offering archery as an opportunity for interaction and character development – is disabled by the emotional and embodied labour of the player in this scene, even though she is not in reality limited by the constraints of Regency gender relations.

Extensively theorised in Nordic larp, this phenomenon is called bleed. Bleed appears 'when role-players sometimes experience moments where their real-life feelings, thoughts, relationships and physical states spill over into their characters and vice versa' (Bowman, 2015). When the player experiences the same fear, and its physical expressions, as the character, it is because of a complex interaction between the real life of the player (her world-view, experiences, emotional baggage, imaginative capacities) and the fictional world of the character. Bleed is clearly connected to the intellectual, emotional and embodied aspects of empathy discussed above. Bleed does not only connect to emotional and embodied empathy. It is also about intellectual perspective-taking. The feeling of being trapped concerns both the character (will I be compromised?) and the player (have the male co-players planned this?), and when the player deals with this, she reacts on all levels simultaneously – intellectually (how to get out of this), emotionally (fear, anxiety) and physically (pounding heart, shaking hands).

Here, imagination plays an important part. Just like intersubjective empathy, intrasubjective empathy is troubled by an epistemological gap, in this case between player and character. The experiences of Mrs Rochester are in many ways unbridgeable for the player because of historical, geographical and social context. The player cannot truly replicate or mimic what it means to be a woman in Regency England. What makes it possible to nonetheless *feel* what it might be like to be a woman in Regency England can be attributed to the way empathy works. An emotion like fear is universal. We know and understand what it feels like to feel fear, regardless of situation. Also, the player (more or less unconsciously) can tap into previous experiences of fear and layer that experience upon the situation at hand. Finally, even though the player has not experienced this kind of situation herself, the ability to *imagine* what it would mean for Mrs Rochester to be compromised allows the player to feel empathy. The willingness of a player to extend her empathic abilities with the help of imagination is an important premise of Nordic larp. Here is an important link to another aspect of intrasubjective empathy, concerning a sense of responsibility and moral imperative to act.

In our everyday experience of the world, our consciousness is directed towards the world, not ourselves. We experience the world from an agent's perspective: 'The unreflective first-person point of view is consciousness not of ourselves, but



FIGURE 7.4 Mrs Rochester and Captain Whiteford.

Credit: Frida Edgar-Selvén and Kalle Lantz

of the world. […] Because it is so unreflective, and because it represents the ordinary, we rarely think of what it is like' (Maibom, p. 178). The question is what happens if we instead take an observer's perspective on ourselves. In her discussion of Jean-Paul Sartre's *Being and Nothingness*, Maibom describes what happens when you, in specific situations, step outside your own agent's perspective and regard your actions with 'the Look of another person (called "The Other")'. Doing so, '[y]ou move from being one with your action to seeing it as this particular action, and you as the person performing it' (p. 177). Thus, as empathy also points inwards, it enables us to lift ourselves out of our narrow pre-reflective way of regarding our own actions (agent perspective). Taking another point of view (observer perspective) implies that we can see our actions in a new light. Maibom argues that this ability is required in order to take responsibility for our actions, and to feel shame. Thus, this ability is the foundation for morality.

The scene above demonstrates how larp makes this even more complex. Immersing in a character means to momentarily abandon one's own agent's perspective on the world and instead take an agent's perspective of the character. For the duration of the larp, the player experiences the world as Mrs Rochester. But she simultaneously brings with her the perspective of her own world (world view, experiences, feelings). This perspective-taking moves back and forth more or less unconsciously throughout the larp. In the scene above, the character/player is experiencing a moment where she takes the "Look" of another on her situation. She realises that she is in fact not a (twentieth-century) woman enjoying a walk-and-talk with a nice man. In a patriarchal world order, she takes the (nineteenth-century) male gaze on her actions as a woman and realises she is in danger. She realises her transgression and feels anxiety and shame. This means that she needs to take responsibility for her actions and handle them accordingly.

At the same time, the scene shows how perspective-taking moves in the opposite direction. The empathic relation between player and character, we argue, makes us aware of our actions, lifting us out of our unreflective view of ourselves, and becoming aware of our actions outside the larp. The moment Mrs Rochester takes the perspective of another on her own actions (with the help of the layered perspective of the player), the player, with the empathy she feels for Mrs Rochester, takes a new perspective of her own actions. The player confronts her own actions with the help of Mrs Rochester's experiences. This happens within the setting of the larp. A lingering sensation for the player is that, had she, indeed, been a Regency woman, she would probably not have taken that stroll in the first place. The liberties she enjoys in the present, real world spilled over to her actions as a woman in Regency England. In some way, the "Look" of Mrs Rochester reflects back on the life of the player, yielding a sense of relief (in the player) of not being a woman in Regency England and a sense of gratefulness for what has been achieved over history in terms of women's liberation. The empathic permeability between character and player

allows for the possibility to 'open our eyes to a greater reality' (Maibom, p. 6), allowing for several perspectives on the world, even within the confined space of the larp.

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Breakfast. Taking leave.

Lady C and I were having breakfast. Edward and Robert come to sit down. Joanna and Alicia were having breakfast with their new families. Phineas as well. Robert had to rush off to his new fiancé. Edward only talking about his engagement. I have a sense of loss, without being able to put a finger on my feeling of sadness. Of wanting to bring Edward close. At the debrief, this dawns upon me. I'm alone. One aspect I had not thought about when deciding not to accept the captain were the strong ties to my family. What a silly cow I am, thinking this would remain. It is Captain Whitstock who first declares his feeling of abandonment and I realise this is what I'm experiencing. I realise that I'm alone and everybody else will be busy with their new lives, and I will have to rely on Lady C for company. What if I'm not gay and strong in London, but only sad and lonely? Instead of feeling strong, I'm feeling shaken. I'm not prepared for this.

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The breakfast scene is informed by a strong sense of loneliness. This emotion emanates from Mrs Rochester's development through *Fortune & Felicity,* a trajectory shaped by interaction with others as well as interplay between character and player. Mrs Rochester rejects a proposal of marriage and instead pursues ideas of liberation and self-fulfilment, choices in line with the player's present-day preferences, but with the unforeseen side-effect of loneliness. Realising that the other family members have fulfilled their characters' narrative trajectories by forming families of their own, Mrs Rochester, and the player with her, feels abandoned. The family will not persist, and the unity upholding her and her sense of liberation is dissolving. Simultaneously, the player realises that the larp is over and the bonds between players are also dissolving. As expressed in the fieldnotes:

It is hard to explain. It is not like we have become friends–since we do know very little about each other. But we have experienced something else together–and that almost makes our bond closer. We have been playing family–a very happy close family.

As we have discussed elsewhere, taking leave of the world of a larp is an extended process which can generate further interaction between players in an almost therapeutic manner (Bjärstorp & Ragnerstam, 2023). Taking leave also has a strong intrasubjective character in the form of post-larp bleed. Having spent days in the storyworld of *Fortune & Felicity,* curtseying, never looking a man straight in the eyes, always constraining posture and movement (with the exception of playing battledore, of course), generated flashbacks as well as lingering emotions and bodily actions and reactions. Just like the player's muscle memory of badminton made itself known in the battledore scene, the physical experience of the larp lasted – it was difficult to stop curtseying also in real life.

Immersion, empathy and the transformative potential of larp

Nordic larp, as we have described, almost always has a political agenda, engaging in difficult topics and questions of power. Yet, its transformative potential does not primarily lie in thematics, but in its capacity to put players in permeable emotional states, immersed and embodied experiences and deeply empathic relations, where they can momentarily leave their own agent's perspective and open up to other perspectives on themselves, on others, and on the world. This does not require grand gestures or violent actions but can build on the subtleties of composing your body in a particular way or adjusting your tone of voice to suit the norms of the storyworld of the larp. Allowing the storyworld, and experiences of it, to bleed into the real world and our actions within it is indeed a kind of responsibility for the Nordic larper.

Empathy is hard work. It is a great emotional and physical commitment and entails self-transformation. Leaving a larp such as *Fortune & Felicity* is strenuous. In playful and joyous moments, as well as in situations of uncertainty and fear, larping means engaging in constant empathic labour. This labour continues when leaving the game, a process of structured debriefing in workshops, continued and spontaneous communication with other players, physical recuperation and emotional processing. How this happens depends on the effort spent establishing and working on empathic relations (both inter- and intrasubjective) during the larp. In the words of one of Petra's final notes, it also entails opening up for the vulnerability of oneself and of others; fulfilling, but, at the same time, highly challenging: 'Not wanting it to end. I want to be with them again. But I do not ever want to do this again'.

Notes

1 *Fortune & Felicity* website (https://anna905.wixsite.com/austenlarp)
2 See also https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Knutepunkt and www.nordiclarp.org.

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